

Baltimore's Informal, Illegal, and Expansive Taxi Network

If you peruse the Baltimore subreddit for long enough, chances are you'll come across a post asking about people making a "pointing at the ground" motion (lemursteamer, 2020). Out-of-towners, newcomers, and suburbanites alike express their confusion: "They stand either close to or in the road, stretch out their arm, and point out the ground with their index finger" (lemursteamer, 2020). "Are they hailing a cab or potentially trying to hitchhike?" (hashtagsmcgee, 2023). "I can't figure out what it means. Are they trying to tell me something?" (eeb1021, 2012). A slew of highly upvoted comments and responses will immediately follow: "Welcome to Baltimore, its [sic] called a 'hack'" (Resident_Structure73, 2023). Hacking is an informal taxi service that—as it is classed as a felony—operates on an "if you know, then you know" basis. This paper will explore how hacking exists as a deregulated and criminalized practice of urban informality.

Referred to by one commenter as an "[in real life] Konami code" (GrittyMcGrittyface, 2023), alluding to the popular video game cheat code where players press a sequence of buttons to unlock a secret portion of the game, the shaking hand motion to request a hack signals to drivers that the person is asking for a paid ride from an "unlicensed, unmarked cab" (Shonuff8, 2023). According to Reddit user anne_hollydaye, "hacking existed LONG before cell phones" (2023), and potentially can be traced "way back to the days of segregation" (GingerMan027, 2023). According to a now-unavailable article from 2004 in the Baltimore City Paper titled "A Baltimore Way of Life," archived in part on the "Illegal taxi operation" Wikipedia page, the name "hack" comes originally from the British term "hackney cab," for taxis, then making its way to the "hack clubs" of Baltimore's working class neighborhoods, where drivers hung around

Baltimore's iconic rowhomes waiting for calls to be picked up. This practice then evolved into the shaking finger motion that has plagued Baltimore's subreddit.

Hacking is a way for Baltimore residents to get around in response to ineffective formal transit modes, relying on reciprocity and interpersonal relationships. It exists in the informal and deregulated, "where ownership, use, and purpose of land cannot be fixed and mapped according to any prescribed set of regulations or the law" (Roy, 2009). To hail a hack "draws on urban social capital within the context of a racialized space to mobilize community transit services" (Johnson, 2013). According to Johnson, a Baltimore native whose family of five relies on hacking to get to work and the grocery store, the price of a hack is informal and loose, reliant on the "vernacular of urban residents." For example, a "round the corner" hack is generally \$2.00 to \$3.00, while going "up the 'ave'" is \$3.00 to \$4.00. To go from the urban city to the suburban county, prices are more like \$6.00 to \$7.00 (Johnson, 2013). However, payment can take many forms. While money is most often expected, it can also be in the form of other currencies of value, especially marijuana (deleted Reddit user, 2023), cigarettes (BmoreScented, 2021), or whatever the rider has in their pocket. But despite the informal payment system, substantive payment is always expected. For residents, this ends up being significantly cheaper and easier than services like Uber and Lyft, which notoriously price gauge users. It also has the benefit of being "much more negotiable" than rideshare services, as people hailing the hack can negotiate the currency, price, duration, and drop-off point based on the needs of the driver picking them up (deleted Reddit user, 2023). In a city like Baltimore, where car reliance is higher than car ownership, this urban informality widens the public realm and helps residents reclaim what Lefebvre calls their "right to the city" (1968). It democratizes access to the street, "moving

across invited and invented spaces of participation” (Miraftab, 2009), serving the “fill the void” where not all residents have cars, or smartphones, or credit cards (nemoran, 2023).

Roy asserts that urban informality is seen as unregulated, when it is more accurate to say that it is deregulated (2009). This holds true with hacking, where there is a sense of social rules, responsibility, and reciprocity. Unlike hitchhiking, which is unpaid and generally involves being taken partway through your journey based on the already-decided route of the driver, hacking is a “calculated informality, one that involves purposive action and planning” (Roy, 2009). One way to better understand the typically unsaid expectations of hacking is by looking at the community guidelines of the many Facebook groups for hacking that have cropped up in recent years. One such group is Baltimore Hack Express, which was established six years ago. It boasts over 2,968 users with 184 posts in the last month, and claims to be “providing transportation and other services in and around Baltimore city & surrounding counties” (*Baltimore Hack Express / Facebook*, 2019). Among the group’s rules is the expectation that all riders will “pay all debts or [they] will be blocked,” and that drivers will not get another hack if they already have committed to picking someone up. Among the consequences for not respecting the rules is that rulebreakers will be “blasted in ALL hack groups & banned” (*Baltimore Hack Express / Facebook*, 2019). This shows that there is a sense of regulation and expectation that has social consequences, which can be seen as citizen-led urbanism, where residents “have the need, the interest and the drive to promote the transformation of public space and improve their quality of life” (Alegre, 2022).

Similar informal structures exist in other places as well: In Roxbury, one of Boston’s majority Black and Latino neighborhoods, infrequent and unreliable bus service means that some MBTA bus drivers know to stop for people who hail them from the side of the road (D. Tavares,

personal communication, September 16, 2024). Washington D.C.'s "Slug Line" is an informal ride service where strangers will give each other rides to work for free, enabling the driver to use the high-occupancy vehicle lane. In the Slug Line, "there are strict rules about not talking to the driver, opening or closing the windows or asking for a change in the radio, or Heat/AC" (132whju, 2023). However, to hack comes with the unique expectation that a hack could be encountered anywhere in the city, and that driver can become a hack at any time.

Despite its social benefits and ubiquity, hacking is classed as a felony (Johnson, 2013) due to the criminalization of unlicensed taxi cab operation in Maryland. This leads to what Johnson calls a "hyper-visible illegality" (2013), where hacks are essential to the social and economic infrastructure of Baltimore's working class neighborhoods, but participating in one makes someone liable to punishment. This pushes the most vulnerable, already failed by decades of historic and ongoing violent planning decisions (among other things), into what Yiftachel calls "gray space," hung between "recognition and destruction, membership and eviction" (2009). Instead of building a robust transit network, which Baltimore's residents have been advocating for for decades (*Red Line Light Rail*, n.d.), the government is criminalizing residents' informal mobility solutions without implementation of proper channels for community support. Also, if an informal taxi solution works, why is there a need to create "proper channels" of taxi licensure—channels that make it near impossible for people who operate hacks on a regular basis to become licensed taxi operators (Staley, 2009)? It's nothing more than infantilization of communities who know their needs best.

In the absence of strong formal scholarship on hacks, this paper was pieced together through one-off comments on social media forums, short essays, and archived articles. In a way, this is perhaps emblematic of what it means to hack: building networks of visible but not

formally recognized support, hoping that someone recognizes your hand signal, waiting for someone to pick you up from the side of the road.

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